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DIPLOMA THESIS PROJECT

Ontological Security of Bosnia



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Introduction

The role of identity in politics is crucial to navigating the modern political landscape, dominated by social media and the internet. Classic political speech, often not accessible unless viewed live in person or on television is commonly accessible through the internet, thus providing greater access to political speech. A fairly recent development in identity politics over the 2010s and 2020s has been ontological security and the role it plays in shaping states' actions (Mitzen, 2006; Kočan, 2023; David, 2019). Although there has been an increase in analysis of ontological security, it has primarily focused on states such as the United States, which are primarily separated by parties in regards to political statements (Mitzen, 2006). The aim of this project is to expand the discourse of ontological security to include states that are highly ethnically charged in order to further grasp the role that ontological security plays in state identity.

The Republic of Bosnia and Herzegovina (BiH) is one of few countries that has a political system that has safeguards to provide equal representation of the different ethnic groups throughout the country, but this provides additional complications to political discourse and national identity. The goal of this project is to determine whether political discourse in BiH maintains a level of cohesion across parties and ethnicities, thus following the assumption that states seek ontological security, or whether disagreement between the parties and ethnicities actively instills ontological insecurity. As well as focusing primarily on discourse by politicians, analysis convey the actions carried out as a result of this discourse and any role that BiH's neighbors may play in BiH's ontological (in)security.

Research Target & Question

This project focuses on the ontological (in)security of Bosnia and how political speeches impact a state's identity. Under the framework set forth by Mitzen (2006, p. 344), states are inclined to seek ontological security, which requires a collective identity that constitutes a state identity. This identity is shaped both internally and externally, but the aim of this research is to understand how the political speeches of Bosnia's politicians shape the identity of the Bosnian state and whether this strengthens or weakens the state's ontological security. The working hypothesis for this project are as follows:

H_1 : There are unified concepts used by politicians in their speeches, regardless of party, that shape the Bosnian state identity.

H_2 : Ontological security shapes the political discourse amongst politicians.

Literature Review

One of the primary works used for conceptualizing the theory of ontological security in regard to states is Jennifer Mitzen's (2006) 2006 article titled *Ontological Security in World Politics: State Identity and the Security Dilemma*. This article expands upon Giddens' (2009) work focusing on how individual identities are constructed, and she applies the concept to state actors as a direct response realist

theorists (Mitzen, 2006, p. 342-344). Mitzen's (2006) application of ontological security is largely covered in the following theoretical framework section, but it created a framework that has been cited in much of the literature on this topic, including much of the literature cited in this project.

There have been a few works that focus on ontological security on BiH, primarily Kočan's book *Identity, Ontological Security and Europeanisation in Republika Srpska* (2023), Lea David's article "Policing Memory in Bosnia" (2019), and Jagiełło-Szostak's "Srebrenica as a Marker of Memory in Bilateral Relations Between Serbia and Bosnia and Herzegovina in the Light of Ontological Security" (2025). A foundation of all of these works is a focus on the memory of BiH and how the Yugoslav Wars, in particular, shape the ontological security of BiH, regardless of ethnic divides (Kočan, 2023, p. 107-119; David, 2019, p. 216-220; Jagiełło-Szostak, 2025, p. 4-5). Despite many similarities in the theoretical approaches to Bosnian identity and ontological security, the subjects of them differ. Kočan (2023, p. 120-125) focuses on Bosnian Serbs, particularly in Srpska Republika, which provides insight into this particular enclave, which constitutes the second largest enclave, that also has a strong impact on foreign relations due to their ties with Serbia. As well focusing directly on Srpska Republika, he also elaborates on how the EU's attempts of *Europeanisation* have strained the ontological security in BiH and internal relations between parties (Kočan, 2023, p. 125-130). As well as substantial insight into the context regarding identity and ontological security of Republika Srpska, Kočan's (2023, p. 149-155) methodological approach follows a similar intended methodology as this project, revolving around content and discourse analysis, providing a strong example of utilizing mixed methods of text analysis for analysis of ontological security and identity. David (2019, p. 216-220) and Jagiełło-Szostak (2025, p. 6-10) put more emphasis on memory in BiH, specifically how it is controlled and utilised, where David focuses on mnemonic politics as a way of shaping identities and ontologies, while Jagiełło-Szostak focuses specifically on the memory of the Srebrenica genocide and the role it plays on the collective memory, especially between the different ethnicities of BiH. Both approaches provide novel ways of working with the fragile and often contentious memories that stem from Balkan history, and particularly the events of the Second World War and the Yugoslav wars.

Due to the complexity of identity, particularly in the Balkans, further context and history was provided by a selection of works, the first of which is Todorova's *Imagining the Balkans* (2009). Todorova (2009, p. 18-19, 38-41) largely expands upon concepts such as *orientalism*, as coined by Said (1979), but does so in a Balkan context that emphasises the history of the region and the perception of the Balkans internally and externally. Her analysis targets the divisions within the understanding of the individual identities throughout the Balkans while also highlighting the *othering* carried out by "Western Europe" on the region as a whole, which often exoticizes the region and its peoples through terms such as *balkanization* or *balkanized* (Todorova, 2009, p. 33-35, 39-41). Another text that is highly influential in understanding the history of the Balkans, and particularly BiH is Andrić's novel *Na Drini Čuprija* (*The Bridge on the Drina*) (1977). *The Bridge on the Drina* discusses the life in Višegrad in the 16th century, but it provides important insight into the mix of identities in BiH and its history (1977). As well as historical context of BiH and the region, the ethnic makeup of BiH

also provides further detail that is of importance to this project. Bringa (2000) provides insight from an anthropologic perspective regarding the mixed identities in BiH and the complex nature Bosnian identity. Bringa's article provides first hand experiences and observations from mixed villages in BiH, and she describes many of the practices that allow for cohabitation, but still distinction between the different ethnicities throughout BiH (Bringa, 2000, p. 82-84). BiH has a complex history, which leads to a similarly complex mix of identities, which also provides a basis for this project, which focuses on politicians' attempts of both leveraging the differences of these identities for particular reasons and attempts to homogenize these identities into a common Bosnian identity as well.

Conceptual & Theoretical Framework

Theory

The overarching concept of this project is ontological security, which is largely attributed to Giddens' (2009) *Modernity and Self Identity*. Ontological security highlights the roll of everyday actions and their impact on self-identity and a sense of safety, thus creating a framework that relies on understanding the consistency of daily actions as well as the potential risks of these actions (Giddens, 2009, p. 36). Trust constitutes one of the ways in which ontological security can be achieved through a emotional and cognitive understanding of the world around someone; as Giddens (2009, p. 38) states, "Basic trust is connected in an essential way to the interpersonal organisation of time and space," which relies on the actions and discourse that occur in interpersonal interaction. For example, an interaction that leads to the intended outcome often strengthens 'basic-trust', whereas interactions that stray from the intended outcome often weaken it. Another crucial element to ontological security is routine, which of the daily actions that are repeated in ones environment that constitute a sense of being and create the framework for self-identity and ontological security (Giddens, 2009, p. 39-40). The final of Giddens' (2009, p. 43) concepts discussed for the purposes of this research is social organisation. Social organisation comes from routines, trust, and mutual understanding, and this largely shapes one's self-identity in relation to the external world and other people (Giddens, 2009, p. 43-44). Concepts like language also constitute social organisation as it requires a mutual understanding of what a word or an object is, what it does, and how it can be used, but through continual repetition of this language, it can form a trusted understanding that is understood by the self (Giddens, 2009, p. 43-45). The combination of these concepts, both on an individual and societal level, create the basis of understanding ontological security, and if there is a disruption to any aspect of self-identity then ontological insecurity may arise.

Expanding upon ontological security as proposed by Giddens (2009), Mitzen (2006) applies these concepts to the state by taking these concepts and applying them to the collective identities that constitute states. As Mitzen (2006, p. 352) discusses, states seek ontological security as a result of the needs of their constituents who seek a stable identity and differentiate themselves from other societies. This need for stable identity by a state's constituents incentivizes maintaining and strengthening national identity, which in many ways is driven

by those who govern the state (Mitzen, 2006, p. 352; Kočan, 2023, p. 29). Furthermore, the actions of politicians can further show the effects of national identities and how members of the collective identity will act in ways that align with it despite possibly acting irrationally as a result (Mitzen, 2006, p. 352). Combining these concepts with theories such as securitisation theory, as Kočan (2023, p. 28-30; Buzan et al., 1998, p. 23-26) poses, provides a framework to analyse how the speech acts of politicians can shape the ontological (in)security. Discursive actions by politicians lead to securitization, but this discourse both influences and is influenced by national identity and ontological security, further perpetuating a consistent narrative with the identity that has been formed (Kočan, 2023, p. 29-31; Buzan et al., 1998, p. 31-32). This ability of discourse to perpetuate identities, as well as the social power placed in the actions of politicians, provides the primary framework for utilizing political speeches to understand the ontological security of BiH (Buzan et al., 1998, p. 32-33).

The combination of these theoretical concepts provides insight into the study of ontological security, identity, and securitisation at a state level, as carried out by politicians, but much of these studies focus on largely cohesive identities that underpin national identity. The case of BiH provides a unique approach to viewing how both political partisanship and ethnic ties affect and are affected by national identity and ontological security. As stated in the constitution of BiH (1995, Annex 4), all parliamentary, executive, and judicial institutions are divided evenly amongst the Bosniaks, Croats, and Serbs, thus leading to political institutions that are shaped by both political and ethnic lines. This disjunction allows for a nuanced approach to determining how BiH seeks and maintains its national identity and ontological security.

Methodology

The methodology used for this project is a mixed methods approach, involving both qualitative and quantitative content and discourse analysis of speeches, parliamentary debates, and party manifestos made by Bosnian politicians from 2010-2020. As of date, the dataset is comprised of 127,713 statements during parliamentary debates (Mochtak et al., 2022), 34 manifestos (Lehmann et al., 2025), and 665 presidential speeches (Presidency of Bosnia and Herzegovina, 2026). These texts will all be translated using OPUS-MT machine translation model designed for slavic languages (Tiedemann et al., 2020). Although the translation of texts using machine translation is not as precise as human translated texts, due to the quantity of texts and methods to be used, this was determined to be the most effective method to translate texts in Bosnian, Croatian, and Serbian. This is carried out as a means of input alignment for further analysis, as working with multilingual corpora provides significant complications on this scale (Hauke Licht et al., 2023, p. 9-10).

The methods used for discourse and content analysis are a mix of machine automated and manual techniques that provide a robust understanding of how political speeches in BiH are affected by identity and if they lead to ontological security or insecurity. Machine automated analysis will be carried out using multiple models, including a roBERTa based model trained using data from the Manifesto Project (2024) to determine various political ideologies and perspectives.

Sentiment analysis will use the CardiffNLP roBERTa based sentiment analysis model ([n.d.]) trained on twitter data, and topic modelling will be done through a version of BERTopic (2022) that will be fine-tuned using a training set of the full corpus. As well as the machine automated analysis, randomly sampled texts from the corpus will undergo manual discourse and content analysis to provide both validation for the use of automated methods and greater context to the use of political speech in BiH.

Planned Outline

The proposed outline for this thesis is as follows:

- Introduction
- Theoretical Framework
- Methodology
- Data
- Emperical Analysis
- Conceptual Analysis
- Conclusion

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